PYTHON FOR DATA SCIENCE · LESSON 2 OF 31

Variables, Data Types, Type Conversion, print(), f-strings & input()

Store and name values with variables, meet Python's core data types (int, float, str, bool, None, complex), convert between types, format output with print(), f-strings and .format(), and read user input with input() and sys.argv.

Python class 2 | Python 3.13 | Beginner | 110 min

By the end of this lesson you can

- Create variables and follow Python naming rules and conventions
- Identify and check types with type() and isinstance(); explain mutable vs immutable
- Convert between int, float, str and bool, and predict what int(), float(), bool() and str() do
- Format output with print() options, f-strings (including number formats) and str.format()
- Read and validate input with input(), and avoid float rounding surprises

Variables

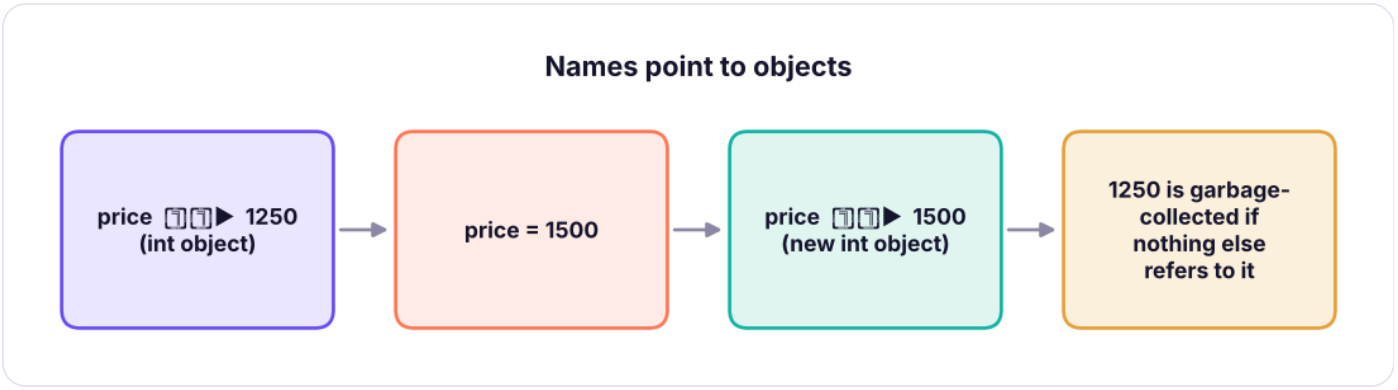
A **variable** is a name that refers to a value stored in memory. You create it by assigning with `=`: no declaration, no type needed.

Python

```
price = 1250          # an int
tax_rate = 0.18       # a float
product = "Laptop"    # a str
in_stock = True       # a bool
total = price * (1 + tax_rate)
print(product, "costs", total)
```

OUTPUT

```
Laptop costs 1475.0
```



A variable is a label attached to an object. Re-assigning moves the label; it does not change the old object.

Naming rules and conventions

Rule	Example
Letters, digits and `_` only; cannot start with a digit	`sales_2025` ✓, `2025_sales` ×
Case-sensitive	`Total` and `total` are different
Cannot be a keyword (`if` , `for` , `class` , `None` , `True` ...)	`class` ×, `class_name` ✓
Convention: `snake_case` for variables and functions, `PascalCase` for classes, `UPPER_CASE` for constants	`monthly_income` , `CustomerOrder` , `GST_RATE`
Use meaningful names	`avg_order_value` not `aov2` or `x`
Avoid shadowing built-ins	Do not name variables `list` , `sum` , `max` , `str` , `id` , `input`

Python

```python
a = b = c = 0                # chained assignment
x, y, z = 1, 2.5, "three"    # multiple assignment (tuple unpacking)
x, y = y, x                  # swap without a temp variable
print(a, b, c, x, y, z)
```

OUTPUT

```
0 0 0 2.5 1 three
```

Data types

Everything in Python is an **object** with a **type**. Check it with `type()` .

Type	Name	Example	Notes
`int`	Integer	`42`, `-7`, `1_000_000`	Unlimited size
`float`	Decimal number	`3.14`, `2e-3`	64-bit binary floating point
`str`	Text	`"Pune"`, `'Pune'`	Immutable sequence of characters
`bool`	Boolean	`True`, `False`	Subclass of int (`True == 1`)
`NoneType`	"nothing"	`None`	Used for missing/absent values
`complex`	Complex number	`3 + 4j`	Rare in data work
`list`, `tuple`, `dict`, `set`	Collections	Lessons 8–10	

Python

```python
values = [42, 3.14, "Pune", True, None, 3 + 4j, [1, 2], (1, 2), {"a": 1}, {1, 2}]
for v in values:
    print(f"{str(v):10s} → {type(v).__name__}")
```

OUTPUT

```
42         → int
3.14       → float
Pune       → str
True       → bool
None       → NoneType
(3+4j)     → complex
[1, 2]     → list
(1, 2)     → tuple
{'a': 1}   → dict
{1, 2}     → set
```

Python

```python
print(isinstance(42, int), isinstance(True, int), isinstance(3.0, (int, float)))   # True True True
print(type(10 / 2), type(10 // 2))      # / always returns float; // with ints returns int
```

OUTPUT

```
True True True
<class 'float'> <class 'int'>
```

Mutable vs immutable

- **Immutable**: cannot be changed after creation: `int`, `float`, `str`, `bool`, `tuple`, `frozenset`. "Changing" creates a new object.
- **Mutable**: can be changed in place: `list`, `dict`, `set`.

Python

```python
s = "data"
try:
    s[0] = "D"                    # strings are immutable
except TypeError as e:
    print("Error:", e)
s2 = "D" + s[1:]                   # build a new string instead
print(s2, "| id changed:", id(s) != id(s2))
```

OUTPUT

```
Error: 'str' object does not support item assignment
Data | id changed: True
```

Numbers: int and float

Python

```python
big = 12_345_678_901_234_567_890 * 10      # ints never overflow
print(big)
print(0.1 + 0.2)                           # floats are approximate!
print(0.1 + 0.2 == 0.3, abs((0.1 + 0.2) - 0.3) < 1e-9)
print(round(2.675, 2), round(0.5), round(1.5), round(2.5))   # banker's rounding: halves go to even
```

OUTPUT

```
123456789012345678900
0.30000000000000004
False True
2.67 0 2 2
```

WATCH OUT **Floating-point surprises**

Computers store decimals in binary, so `0.1 + 0.2` is `0.30000000000000004`. For **money** use `decimal.Decimal` (or integers of paise); for comparisons use `math.isclose(a, b)` or `abs(a - b) < tolerance`. Python's `round()` rounds halves to the nearest even number (`round(2.5) = 2`), unlike Excel's `ROUND`.

Python

```
from decimal import Decimal
print(Decimal("0.1") + Decimal("0.2"))                    # exact decimal arithmetic
import math; print(math.isclose(0.1 + 0.2, 0.3))
```

OUTPUT

```
0.3
True
```

Booleans and None

Python

```
print(True + True, 5 > 3, 5 == 5.0, "a" < "b", not False)
print(bool(0), bool(0.0), bool(""), bool([]), bool(None))      # all False: "falsy" values
print(bool(1), bool(-3), bool("0"), bool([0]))                 # all True: anything else
is "truthy"
print(None is None, type(None))
```

OUTPUT

```
2 True True True True
False False False False False
True True True True
True <class 'NoneType'>
```

Falsy values: `0`, `0.0`, `""`, `[]`, `{}`, `()`, `set()`, `None`, `False`. Everything else is truthy. `None` represents "no value" (like SQL NULL); test with `is None`, never `== None`.

Type conversion

Convert with the type's name: `int()`, `float()`, `str()`, `bool()`, `list()`...

Python

```
print(int("42"), int(3.99), int(-3.99), int(True))          # int() truncates towards zero
print(float("3.5"), float(7), float("1e3"))
print(str(123), str(3.0), str([1, 2]))
print(int("1010", 2), int("ff", 16), bin(10), hex(255))     # other bases
print(round(3.7), round(3.14159, 2), int(round(3.7)))
```

OUTPUT

```
42 3 -3 1
3.5 7.0 1000.0
123 3.0 [1, 2]
10 255 0b1010 0xff
4 3.14 4
```

Python

```
print("5" + 3)                    # TypeError: can only concatenate str to str
```

OUTPUT

```
TypeError: can only concatenate str (not "int") to str
```

Python

```
print("5" + str(3), int("5") + 3, "5" * 3)      # explicit conversion; repetition for strings
```

OUTPUT

```
53 8 555
```

Python

```
int("abc")                        # ValueError: invalid literal for int()
```

OUTPUT

```
ValueError: invalid literal for int() with base 10: 'abc'
```

Conversion	Result	Note
`int("42")`	42	String must look like an integer
`int("3.7")`	ValueError	Convert to float first: `int(float("3.7"))`
`int(3.99)`	3	Truncates (not rounds)
`float("abc")`	ValueError	
`str(None)`	`'None'`	
`bool("False")`	True	Any non-empty string is True!
`list("abc")`	`['a','b','c']`	

Implicit conversion happens in mixed arithmetic: `int + float → float`, `bool + int → int`.

Python

```
print(1 + 2.0, True + 1, type(1 + 2.0).__name__)
```

OUTPUT

```
3.0 2 float
```

print(): showing output

Python

```
print("Order", 1001, "shipped")                    # items separated by a space
print("Order", 1001, "shipped", sep=" | ")          # change the separator
print("Loading", end="...")                          # change the line ending (no newline)
print("done")
print("Line one\nLine two\tTabbed")                  # escape sequences: \n newline, \t tab
print('He said "hi"', "It's fine", 'It\'s fine')     # quotes inside strings
print(r"C:\new\table")                               # raw string: backslashes kept
print("""A multi-line
string with triple quotes""")
```

OUTPUT

```
Order 1001 shipped
Order | 1001 | shipped
Loading...done
Line one
Line two        Tabbed
He said "hi" It's fine It's fine
```

```
C:\new\table
A multi-line
string with triple quotes
```

f-strings: the modern way to format

Put `f` before the quotes and `{expression:format}` inside:

Python

```python
name, qty, price, share = "Asha", 3, 1234.5678, 0.2345
print(f"{name} bought {qty} items")
print(f"Price: {price:.2f}")                # 2 decimals
print(f"Price: {price:,.2f}")               # thousands separator
print(f"Share: {share:.1%}")                # percentage
print(f"ID: {qty:03d}")                      # zero-padded to 3 digits
print(f"[{name:<10}] [{name:>10}] [{name:^10}]")       # left, right, centre in width 10
print(f"{price:>12,.1f}|")                   # right-aligned width 12
print(f"{qty * price:,.2f}  {qty = }")       # expressions work; {x = } prints name and value
print(f"{1234567:,}  {255:#x}  {255:b}  {0.000123:.2e}")
```

OUTPUT

```
Asha bought 3 items
Price: 1234.57
Price: 1,234.57
Share: 23.4%
ID: 003
[Asha      ] [      Asha] [   Asha   ]
     1,234.6|
3,703.70  qty = 3
1,234,567  0xff  11111111  1.23e-04
```

Format spec	Meaning
`.2f`	2 decimal places (fixed)
`,`	Thousands separator
`.1%`	Percentage with 1 decimal
`05d`	Integer padded with zeros to width 5
`<10`, `>10`, `^10`	Left / right / centre in width 10
`e`	Scientific notation
`x`, `b`, `o`	Hex, binary, octal

.format() and % (older styles)

Python

```
print("{} bought {} items at {:.1f}".format("Asha", 3, 12.345))
print("{1} before {0}".format("B", "A"))
print("{name} paid {amt:,.0f}".format(name="Ravi", amt=1234567))
print("%s bought %d items at %.1f" % ("Asha", 3, 12.345))        # legacy, still seen in
old code
```

OUTPUT

```
Asha bought 3 items at 12.3
A before B
Ravi paid 1,234,567
Asha bought 3 items at 12.3
```

Prefer **f-strings** in new code; you will meet `.format()` and `%` in older code and logs.

Reading input

`input()` reads **text** from the keyboard and always returns a `str`:

Python

```
name = input("Your name: ")                    # waits for the user
age = int(input("Your age: "))                 # convert to a number
height = float(input("Height in metres: "))
print(f"Hello {name}, you are {age} and {height:.2f} m tall.")
```

Because this handbook runs without a keyboard, here is the same logic with the typed values supplied in code:

Python

```
typed = ["Asha", "29", "1.62"]           # imagine the user typed these three answers
name = typed[0]; age = int(typed[1]); height = float(typed[2])
print(f"Hello {name}, you are {age} and {height:.2f} m tall.  In ten years: {age + 10}.")
```

OUTPUT

```
Hello Asha, you are 29 and 1.62 m tall.  In ten years: 39.
```

Validate input

Python

```
while True:
    text = input("Enter quantity (1-100): ")
    if text.isdigit() and 1 ⩽ int(text) ⩽ 100:
        quantity = int(text); break
    print("Please type a whole number between 1 and 100.")
```

Other ways to get values into a program: **command-line arguments** (`sys.argv` , `argparse`), **files** (Lesson 13), **databases and APIs** (later lessons), and **environment variables** (`os.environ["API_KEY"]`) for secrets.

Useful built-in functions

Python

```
nums = [4, 8, 15, 16, 23, 42]
print(len(nums), sum(nums), min(nums), max(nums), sorted(nums, reverse=True))
print(abs(-7), pow(2, 5), divmod(17, 5), round(sum(nums) / len(nums), 2))
print(type(nums).__name__, id(nums) > 0, dir(3)[:3])          # introspection helpers
help(len) if False else None                                   # help(len) prints
documentation
```

OUTPUT

```
6 108 4 42 [42, 23, 16, 15, 8, 4]
7 32 (3, 2) 18.0
list True ['__abs__', '__add__', '__and__']
```

Mini project: a bill calculator

Python

```
items = {"Notebook": (45.0, 10), "Pen pack": (60.0, 25), "Stapler": (180.0, 4)}     # name: (price, quantity)
GST = 0.18
subtotal = 0
print(f"{'Item':<12}{'Price':>8}{'Qty':>5}{'Amount':>10}")
for name, (price, qty) in items.items():
    amount = price * qty; subtotal += amount
    print(f"{name:<12}{price:>8.2f}{qty:>5}{amount:>10,.2f}")
print("-" * 35)
print(f"{'Subtotal':<25}{subtotal:>10,.2f}")
print(f"{'GST (18%)':<25}{subtotal * GST:>10,.2f}")
print(f"{'Total':<25}{subtotal * (1 + GST):>10,.2f}")
```

OUTPUT

```
Item           Price  Qty    Amount
Notebook       45.00   10    450.00
Pen pack       60.00   25  1,500.00
Stapler       180.00    4    720.00
-----------------------------------
Subtotal                   2,670.00
GST (18%)                    480.60
Total                      3,150.60
```

(The `for` loop and dictionary are explained in Lessons 6 and 9; notice how f-string alignment makes a tidy table.)

Summary

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- A **variable** is a name pointing to an object; names are `snake_case`, case-sensitive, and must not be keywords or shadow built-ins.
- Core types: `int`, `float`, `str`, `bool`, `NoneType`; `list/tuple/dict/set` come later. Check with `type()` and `isinstance()`.
- Strings, numbers and tuples are **immutable**; lists, dicts and sets are **mutable**.
- Floats are approximate (`0.1 + 0.2`): use `Decimal` for money and `math.isclose` for comparisons. `round()` uses banker's rounding.
- Convert with `int()`, `float()`, `str()`, `bool()`; `int("3.7")` fails, `int(3.99)` truncates, `bool("False")` is True.
- Format with **f-strings** (`{x:,.2f}`, `{p:.1%}`, `{n:05d}`, `{s:<10}`); `print` has `sep` and `end`.
- `input()` returns a string: convert and validate it.

Quick quiz

6 questions · tap an answer to check it

1. What does `type(10 / 2)` return?

A `int`

B `float`

C `str`

D `bool`

Answer: B. `/` always returns a float in Python 3 (5.0).

2. What is `int(-3.9)` ?

A −4

B −3

C 3

D −3.9

Answer: B. int() truncates towards zero.

3. Which is NOT falsy?

A `0`

B `""`

C `"0"`

D `None`

Answer: C. A non-empty string, including "0", is truthy.

4. What does `print(f"{0.2345:.1%}")` print?

A 0.2

B 23.4%

C 2.3%

D 0.23

Answer: B. `.1%` multiplies by 100 and shows one decimal. 0.2345 displays as 23.4% because 0.2345 is stored as a binary value just below 0.2345.

5. `x = input("Age: ")` and the user types 25. What is `type(x)`?

A `int`

B `str`

C `float`

D `bool`

Answer: B. input() always returns text.

6. Why is `0.1 + 0.2 == 0.3` **False?**

A Python is buggy

B Decimal fractions cannot be represented exactly in binary floating point

C Because of integer division

D Because of rounding to even

Answer: B. Use math.isclose or Decimal.

EXERCISE **Practice**

(1) Ask for a price and quantity (simulate the input), compute the total with 18% GST and print it as `₹1,23,456.78`-style with thousands separators and 2 decimals. (2) Convert "1010" from binary to int and 255 to hex. (3) Explain the output of `print(round(2.5), round(3.5))`.

Show solution (worked answer)

Python

```python
price, qty = float("1250.5"), int("3")
total = price * qty * 1.18
print(f"Total: ₹{total:,.2f}")          # ₹4,426.77
print(int("1010", 2), hex(255))          # 10 0xff
print(round(2.5), round(3.5))            # 2 4 : halves round to the nearest even number
```

INTERVIEW CORNER **Questions you may be asked**

Q: What is the difference between mutable and immutable types? Give examples. Immutable objects cannot change after creation (int, float, str, tuple); mutable ones can (list, dict, set). It matters for function arguments, dictionary keys (must be immutable/hashable) and copying.

Q: What is the output of `bool("False")` and why? True: any non-empty string is truthy, regardless of its content.

Q: How do you compare floats safely? `math.isclose(a, b)` or `abs(a - b) < tol`; use `Decimal` for exact decimal arithmetic such as money.

Q: `is` vs `==`? `==` compares values; `is` compares identity (same object). Use `is None` for None.

Practise more online

Free, trusted places to test yourself on this topic. Links open the original site in a new tab.